



PRAMOD PUSHKARNA

10

smartest political moves

Games our leaders play to usurp power and cling to it. From Mrs Gandhi's manipulation to Mayawati's social engineering.

1 Coalition unites against Mrs Gandhi, March 1977

"The people had said a resounding 'no' to the tyranny and oppression which had marked 19 months of Congress rule," said INDIA TODAY. The Janata Party-led coalition rode into power on a surge of anger.

2 Mrs Gandhi refuses bail, October 1977

Mrs Gandhi staged a political comeback when she refused to seek bail after being arrested on corruption charges by the CBI in October 3, 1977. INDIA TODAY stated, "In the eyes of her nation's illiterate millions, the Janata Party had become the Big Bad Wolf and Mrs Gandhi had acquired the status of the Joan of Arc."



SHARAD SAXENA

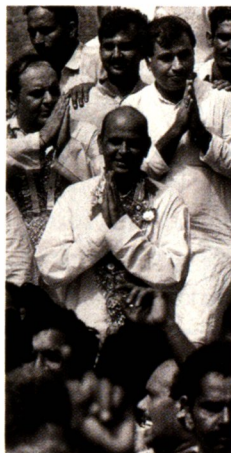


3 Congress chooses Rajiv Gandhi to replace Indira, December 1984

"They are quick to realise that their only banner is gone. This is the last chance to come back to power on the sympathy wave" (INDIA TODAY, December 1984). Congress won 401 out of the 508 contested seats—the highest since Independence.

4 V.P. Singh props up Devi Lal, becomes PM, November 1990

"In upholding principles, I am not a disaster. In following that, one has to go down a dangerous path," said V.P Singh to INDIA TODAY in November 1990. He led the National Front to a euphoric victory in 1989 and proposed Devi Lal's name as prime minister, who refused the nomination and insisted that Singh be the one.



5 Chandra Shekhar is PM with 56 MPs, December 1990

Twenty-eight years after he first walked into Parliament in 1962, Chandra Shekhar became the prime minister with only 56 MPs. "In the process of forming his ministry, Chandra Shekhar demonstrated that he is still an adept player of the double con" (INDIA TODAY, December 1990).